

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT

Designing Worlds: Story, Sound, and Code

1. GAME OVERVIEW

Working Title

The University Mace

One-Sentence Premise

Describe your game in one compelling sentence. Try a “What if...?” or “Imagine...” formulation.

Imagine you’ve attended your father’s procession at Sewanee, and an artifact with ties to the KKK is flaunted as part of the ceremony, and you become so enraged to the point you seek to find and destroy the *University Mace*, yet it isn’t as simple as it first seems.

Elevator Pitch

In one short paragraph, describe the game, the player, and what makes it interesting.

The game takes place in 1965 on the Sewanee campus, during December right around when people are beginning to leave for winter break. Everything about the campus seems as normal as ever, and you’re simply a student among many in the daylight. Your character is unnamed, but the game builds out this character as more of their story/past is described. You aren’t just playing as a blank slate, or as yourself, but immersing yourself in a preset character and making their choices. But, the interesting part of this game is that it’s about not just finding the *University Mace*, but also figuring out how to dispose/destroy it (the real puzzle), hiding this fact from others, and potentially even the consequences of the methods you choose to do so throughout.

2. THE PLAYER'S EXPERIENCE

Who is the player?

Who does the player take the role of? What do they know when the game begins?

The player takes the role of an active student at Sewanee in 1965. The game begins immediately in the middle of their dead father’s holy procession, and the *University Mace* is quickly noticed in the middle of the chapel, of which the character knows its history. Alongside that, the main character’s reaction, and the following, strong urge to deal with this artifact. They notice a student carrying this Mace after the procession, but cannot see exactly where it’s stored/hidden. This is when it truly begins.

What does the player want?

What is the player's goal?

Find the mace, then find a way to dispose/destroy it without being caught.

What does the player actually do?

Describe the core activities: exploring, investigating, solving puzzles, talking, collecting, making choices, surviving, etc.

A small selection of puzzles / investigating leading up to finding the Mace, then an increase in puzzle difficulty as the Mace has to be rid of (The character will be prevented going places or committing certain actions based on nearby students/faculty, and ones that'll obviously lead to being caught. The character is smart, and the player works around this, solving the puzzles presented to them).

3. THE WORLD

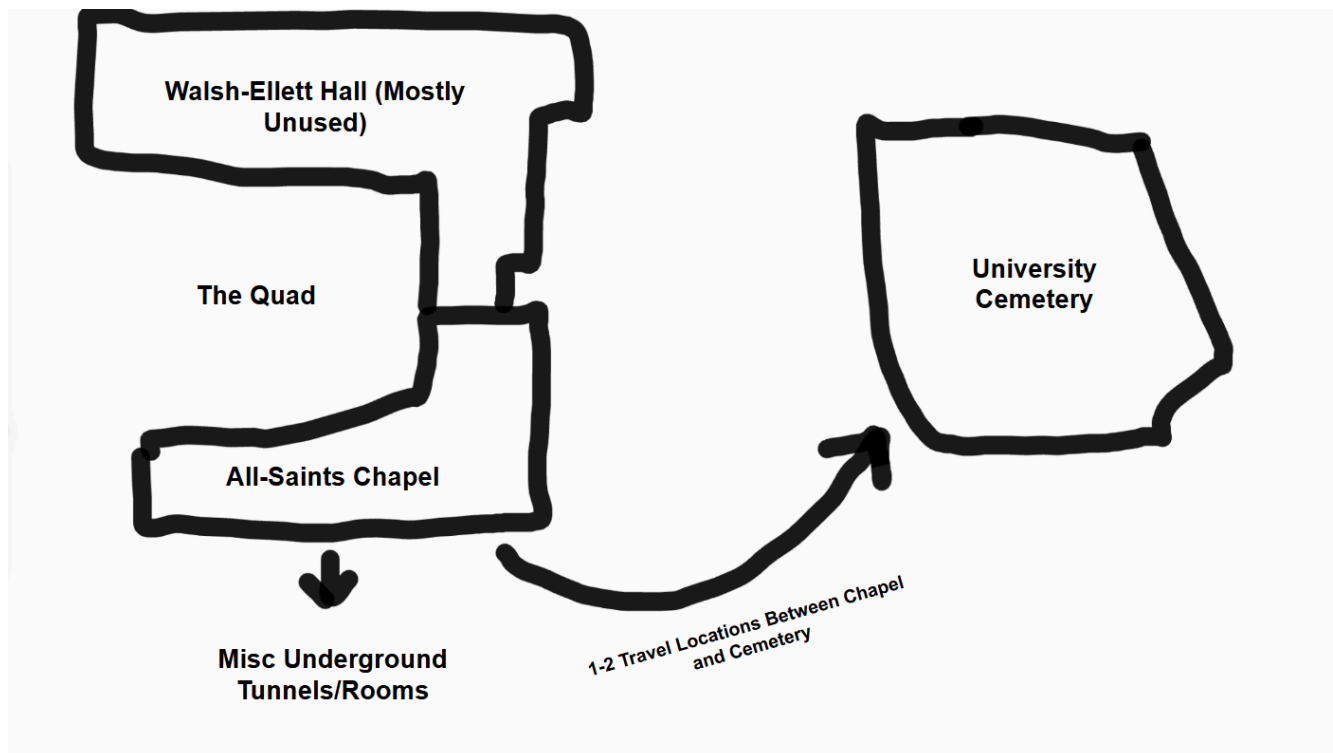
Where does the game take place?

Describe the locations. The game must be rooted in the Sewanee campus or Domain, but the story can be realistic, historical, fantastical, science fictional, mysterious, frightening, comedic, or surreal.

The locations include All Saint's Chapel, some disconnected underground tunnels / rooms, and the cemetery, plus surrounding areas in those locations. It's not too much.

World Map

Include a simple map showing the major locations and how they connect.



4. STORY

What happens?

Describe the beginning, central conflict or mystery, major events, and possible endings.

In 1965 a student goes to the procession of his father at Sewanee, who recently became a professor at the college. But the student is horribly offended when the recently-blessed Nathan Bedford Forrest ceremonial mace is used as decoration within the chapel during the ceremony. They cannot help their rage anymore, so they go on a quest to destroy this KKK artifact once and for all.

There are no major events in the middle of the story, maybe aside from the point where the player first gets their hands on the mace. The story is driven through the puzzles/stealth, and the constant dread of something interrupting/exposing that quest.

The Priest guards the chapel, creating a secondary conflict which only matters at a few points during the game's duration. He's not a constant threat prowling the map, of course.

There are different possible endings. The player can destroy the artifact and get away with it... Or they can get caught without having destroyed it, or could even get caught after the fact. It all depends on how sloppy the player went about their mission.

Key Characters

For each important character, describe their name, role, what they want, and relationship to the player.

1. The Player Character - *Unnamed* - They want to find/destroy the Mace - This is the player
2. The Player's Father - *Unnamed* - Their role is to pretty much just die, which they do - Father of the player
3. The Priest - *The Priest* - They are practically the only physical antagonist in a sense, as they stay within the All-Saints Chapel and make it harder for the Player Character to quietly carry out everything needed to achieve their goal - The Priest's goal is to keep peace within the All-Saints Chapel, and to protect whatever's in it - They are a priest for the chapel residing at the school the player goes to

5. INTERACTION

Important Actions

What commands or actions will the player use?

The player will be able to select commands/actions through a provided list of options (like 2-6 depending on the circumstance). If the player has the option to use objects on something, that will be one choice which will branch out to include all possible interactions based on your inventory, and any actions requiring unknown items would be grayed out of course. Same thing for any potential option to interact with, or to use something to interact with the environment.

Interactive Objects

List several objects that matter to the game and what the player can do with them.

Some objects the player will come across will be *The University Mace*, a shovel, sticks and rocks, etc... Sticks and rocks would be able to interact with other people / the environment, as you can destroy fragile objects from distances, and make noise to distract people, among many other things. The mace, of course, can be used as a tool/weapon, but can also interact with the environment in ways that could damage/destroy it. Plus, the shovel could be used as a tool to reach/push objects from high-up, to dig, and to even potentially open doors... Or to block them from being opened.

6. PUZZLES AND CHALLENGES

Major Puzzles

Identify 2–5 major puzzles, challenges, or decisions. For each, describe the goal, needed information or objects, what the player must figure out, and why the challenge is interesting.

One decision will be near the beginning, either heading to the cemetery or staying at the chapel. Not much info is needed, and the player will just be starting out, but this decision will influence how the player begins solving the mysteries/puzzles. And one major puzzle would definitely be stealing the Mace from its place in the basement room (which first has to be found with the right information). It's in a glass case, and there's no telling what'll happen if the glass is broken, so the player either has to find a method to open the cage (like with a key), or even influencing the *The Priest* to take the Mace out of the cage and to place it back in the main room. Who knows, breaking the glass is still an option, but that'll require a prior trip to the cemetery to safely carry out (rocks/sticks, the shovel could be useful here)?

7. SOUND & MUSIC

Music

What music will the player hear? Where will it appear or change?

The music will be eerie and spooky, maybe when the player is closer to the main goal the music will be enchanting. If the player makes good decisions in the game reward them with small positive sound effects.

Sound Effects

What actions or events should have sounds?

Opening items, changing rooms, making wrong/right choices.

Ambient Sound

What sounds establish the setting?

Because our game will be spooky, all sounds will most likely be eerie and meant to make you feel like you are on a real quest.

Silence

Are there moments where silence is especially important?

Maybe right before something scary or frightening happens to build suspicion.

8. THE FIRST FIVE MINUTES

Opening Experience

Describe what happens when someone starts your game: what they see, learn, and can do, and what question or mystery makes them want to continue.

First 2.5 Minutes: The player is immediately put into a limited situation. They are touring Sewanee with their father (who just applied to be a professor), and the scene takes place in the All Saints Chapel. The

University Mace is strung up, and the tour guide explains part of its history. The player is able to select some dialogue options to talk with this guide (in one path, the player learns a supposed 'myth' of an entrance in All Saints to a secret basement. In another path, the player learns the name of the room where the mace is stored), but the scene fades away rather quickly, and the player begins listing memories with their father. There is only one option to pick, "remember." And suddenly...

Second 2.5 Minutes: The player is transported right into the midst of their father's procession in the All Saints Chapel. He died. The scene is set. The player can progress through the ceremony, and along the way, we notice *The University Mace* hung up as a decoration and slowly set up the growing discomfort/hatred brewing within the player's heart. Some one-off details about the environment, potential objects, rooms, and hiding places are described. Once we get to the end of the main ceremony, and the player is invited to walk out to the cemetery to bury the ashes, multiple options are presented. To stay behind for the mace, or to walk out to the cemetery. The cemetery will grant you access to discover more possibilities for later on, and staying behind will help make finding the mace easier. And now the player knows fully what to do.

9. SCOPE

Must Have

Things the game absolutely needs.

The game needs to have the basics. The selectable choices/options that branch off one another, the story, the music, and maybe even one or so accessibility features such as being able to see all your past choices (a simple log).

Nice to Have

Things you'd like to include if time permits.

If time permits, additional options to view sketches/objects/photographs picked up along the adventure would be cool. Visual elements in general, like a viewable inventory that updates, could be nice to have.

Probably Too Much

Ideas you like but probably should not attempt this semester.

Something like a visual sketch of the general map that updates with what you discover would be too much to add this semester. Anything that even brings the slightest bit of extra complexity to the game would probably be too much.

10. TEAM RESPONSIBILITIES

Computer Science

What will need to be programmed?

I am thinking of using a choice engine where the player is presented with 2-6 contextual options at a time. The program will need to be able to track what choices they've made. The options will depend on where the player is and how far along the game they are. We will also want to have a choice log feature so they

player can track their moves throughout the game. Lastly depending on the amount of items we want the player to collect we may add an inventory for items.

Creative Writing

What will need to be written?

I'll need to write the general story outline, from beginning to middle to end. Then I'll have to write out the pool of objects, the locations, the progression of each branching/possible choice, etc... Later on, I'll have to begin writing the actual meat of every single scene/description, transforming a broad outline into something that can be finally pieced together into the game.

Music

What will need to be composed, recorded, or designed?

I'll need to find inspiration from the story line to help fit the game, and make it sound accurate to the feeling people get while playing the game to enhance the experience.

Collaboration

Identify at least two places where programming, writing, and music need to influence one another.

1. suspicion/detection system - writing team need to make clear which actions increase or lower suspicion. The programming team needs to be able to assign numbers to the level of suspicion. The music team will have to build their sounds around the differing levels of suspicion while incorporating silence in it.
2. Myth of secret basement entrance - The programmer needs to know (from the writer) which flags that conversation sets in the opening scene as this will dictate what is available for the player in the later basement puzzle.

11. DEVELOPMENT PLAN

Major Milestones

List the major things your team needs to accomplish.

1. For the story aspect, we'll need to complete a rough event outline, lightly detailing all the possibilities. Then we'll need to write out the content of each branching path and decision.
2. For the music aspect, we'll need to develop the music based on the different locations in the game, and based on different points throughout the story.
3. For the programming aspect, we'll need to develop a prototype that proves we can deliver the basics of a text-based adventure game, then we'll move on to building/polishing that system further and implementing the full story.

12. WHAT ARE WE STILL FIGURING OUT?

Open Questions

Identify 2-3 questions or uncertainties your team still needs to explore.

1. How long would the game reasonably be?
2. How many options and branching paths should be included for what the game needs?

THE TEST

Give your GDD to someone who is not on your team. Ask them to read it, then ask: “Tell us what you think our game is.” If their description is substantially different from yours, revise the GDD. The goal is to create a shared vision that your team can actually build.